

## Repairs

For many years there stood on Salt Street, between the clockmaker's and a shop that sold only umbrellas, a bindery that took walk-in work at the front — loose spines, torn jackets, hymnals gone soft with kissing — under a sign that said, in the spelling of two reforms ago, REPAIRS. The appointment work was done in the back. In the back, Metodi wrote last lines for books that could not end themselves.

He read nothing of a manuscript but its first line. On this he was absolute. Authors who arrived with the whole bundle, wrapped in string, watched him turn it face down — a surgeon declining the chart. The last line follows from the first, he said, as the shape of a door follows from its frame; the rest was the author's private business, and he wished to know none of it.

He charged by the year — of the writing, not of his trouble — so that the slow paid dearly and the fluent next to nothing, an arrangement he considered the only honest one in publishing. The ledger took the title, the first line, and the fee, and nothing else. Of the lines he supplied he kept no copy. An ending kept loose, he said, goes off like milk.

Vera Antimova, whose detectives were beloved and whose murderers she could never bring herself to hang, came every autumn. For *The Orchard at Vidin*, which begins: *The frost came early that year, and the apples stayed on the branch, and so did Simeon*, he gave her: *The orchard kept its fruit that winter, and the town, which knew everything, elected to know nothing*. The reviewers called it mercy. Antimova called it a stay of execution, renewable annually, and was back the next autumn with another first line and the same trouble.

The national epic had no ending; the poem breaks off mid-line at the crossing of a river, where the original singer is presumed to have been interrupted for good. In the year the Ministry took an interest, a delegation arrived with the invocation copied out fair. He supplied the ending. It was adopted by decree, set for memorization in the schools, and within a generation three scholars had discovered, independently, that it had been in the oldest manuscripts all along. He billed for six centuries. The Ministry paid.

A poet asked for his last line in advance — something to write toward. Metodi took the man's first line, gave him his last, and made no comment. The poet framed it, hung it above his desk, and wrote nothing further for the rest of

a long and, by his own account, contented life. Metodi counted him among the successes.

The Academy's dictionary had been forty years reaching the last letter, its editors dying alphabetically. When the survivors came, he wrote the final entry in an afternoon: *ATO — a flock, of birds or of years*. The dictionary was published to acclaim and was in revision within twelve months, the language having failed to stop. He had warned them of this.

A cookbook had lost its author between the soups and the stews; the widow wanted nothing invented — she wanted to be able to close it. He closed it.

Memoirs he did not take, at any price, and the prices offered were sometimes remarkable. A memoir's last line, he said, is not the author's to write. He was not in that trade.

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Sevda came in March, on the 17:40, with a first line and nothing after it. She had been carrying it for two years, and it had worn smooth from the handling. *My grandmother's house had a door for people and a door for weather, and one morning she confused them.*

He read it twice. She paid for the two years in coins, counted out on the glass, and he took all of it. She went home and wrote the fourteen chapters the two lines insisted on.

The book went through four printings. The next March she was back with a new first line, and after that every March, on the same train, until in the shop the season was simply called by her name.

When the printed copies came by post he would shut the shop at midday and read them through — middles and all, the only reading of that kind he was ever known to do — and the kettle went cold while he read.

What they were to each other the ledger does not say. Neither of them kept any other record.

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He died in March, in the chair at the back, with the front room full of other people's spines.

In the ledger, on the last used page, there was a loose sheet, folded once. A first line, in his hand: *I was born above the shop, in the year of the two winters, and I was late even for that.*

Sevda read it standing in the doorway, still in her coat. She saw the last line at once — you could watch her see it, the clockmaker's wife said — and she folded the sheet along its crease and put it away, and she has never told anyone what it is.

The Municipal Museum keeps the ledger now, under glass, open to a page of no particular interest. Whether Sevda is writing the book she has not said.

The shop is a pharmacy now. Nobody has taken down the sign.